'OUR *VANVAAS* HAS DRAGGED ON ENDLESSLY'

AKHTAR RANGREJ, 40

Garments business owner and social worker ▼

Our family of 12 stays in an 8x8 ft tenement. I was born in Dharavi and it is our dream that the children have good houses to live in. Dharavi has produced doctors, engineers and professionals despite every adversity. We can do even better if we get the facilities. Our houses lack ventilation and natural light and we live so cheek by jowl we can smell what the neighbours are cooking. But there is a question on our minds. Does the state have the will to ensure Dharavi is developed? Lord Ram's *vanvaas* lasted for only 14 years, ours has been dragging on forever.



counted rates, lower than the rates of Rs 50,000-80,000 per sq. ft in BKC, but prices may rise later.

RESIDENTS IN A BIND

Dharavi's residents, though, are not happy with the opacity around the plans. A key concern is that the redevelopment will be treated more as a real-estate development project instead of a resettlement one. Opposition leader Mane says around 5,000 small and big industrial units in the area provide direct or indirect employment to Dharavi residents, and they fear being pushed out to make way for an extended BKC. Dhansukh Parmar, a resident of the 12.5-acre Dharavi *kumbharwada*, which got its name from the Gujarati potters who settled there in the early 20th century, notes that much of the project planning was top-down and did not take into account the views of the locals. The *kumbharwada* has around 2,000 families and around 110 *bhattis* (kilns) to make earthen products, which are exported to countries like Australia, Singapore and Malaysia. Parmar wonders how their business needs will be incorporated into the redevelopment plans. Chetan Chauhan from the *kumbharwada* says many of them have houses as large as 2,000-3,000 sq. ft, and are not willing to settle for smaller tenements.

Owners of local industrial units, like Raju Khade, who has a manufacturing facility for leather and faux leather goods, say they want an industrial hub within Dharavi. "Today, many residential structures double up as manufacturing units. But when buildings are built in their place, it is obvious these families will not be able to work like in the past," he says.

Naturally, Dharavi needs an empathetic urban planning approach for the many complexities involved. Ex-DRP chief and former chairman of the Maharashtra Real Estate Regulatory Authority (MahaRERA) Gautam Chatterjee says, "Ultimately, we have to understand that Dharavi is not a simple slum but an industrial township.... My fear is, in terms of looks, the eyesore may go away, and we will have a swanky city. But if you say this is a redevelopment project for the purpose of rehabilitation, then you must be very careful...there must be the least amount of displacement," he says. Chatterjee says the survey to identify eligible households, their numbers and occupations will be crucial in this.

Both Adani Properties and the state government are trying to address these concerns. In response to a detailed questionnaire, an Adani Properties spokesperson said: "Our balance sheet is very strong and we are confident about arranging the financing for the project. The fears and concerns raised by vested parties about us meeting the project's financial obligations are unwarranted.... The residents of Dharavi are central to our planning and execution. There will be no change in our implementation schedule after receiving the LoA (letter of award)."

Srinivas, too, talks about taking the residents into confidence. "We will have a masterplan that addresses most of these issues after the MoU is signed. It will earmark the open spaces and community structures," he says. "The project already has penalty clauses. If there are delays, the market itself imposes penalty clauses due to a delay in releasing the resale component...and a growth in the cost of construction."

As of now, the idea of redevelopment evokes both hope and trepidation among the residents of Dharavi. The simplest of things, such as owning a house with an attached toilet, have never seemed more real. "Eve-teasing and harassment are common at the public toilets. Once we get flats, we will have toilets in our house," says Korde enthusiastically. But, as Dharavi Business Forum ex-president Anjum Shaikh points out, "Just developing the land will have no meaning if the people are forced to leave. Then it will only be populated by a few crorepatis." And if that happens, Dharavi will cease to be Dharavi, the centuries-old melting pot of dreams and aspirations that has come to stand for working-class Mumbai. ■